Ron's Retirement Finance Model V1

A plain-English onboarding guide for setup, Roth Lab, Bucket Lab, check-ins, and advisor conversations

Start with the Setup Guide. It is the front door to the model. It asks for information in a safer order, explains what each answer means, checks what is missing, and keeps most people away from the raw tables.

Quick translation: you do not need to understand every finance term before using the app. Build a reasonable baseline, use Readiness to find missing pieces, then use Roth Lab, Bucket Lab, or Strategy Builder only when you are ready to test choices.

USE THIS GUIDE FIRST Read the first sections to understand why the app exists and how to get a useful first report.	**USE REFERENCE LATER** The field details are near the back. Do not start there unless a screen or field is confusing.
ADVISOR USE The Roth Lab and Bucket Lab report sections are designed to create better questions, not to replace professional advice.	**NOT ADVICE** This is a planning tool. It is not tax, legal, investment, Medicare, or financial advice.

1. What This App Does

Most retirement calculators ask one question: will the money last? This app tries to answer a more useful question: where should money come from each year, what tax and Medicare effects does that create, and when should taxable income be created on purpose for Roth conversions?

The model still tracks balances year by year, but the real value is that it turns retirement cash flow into choices you can discuss.

Job	Plain-English Meaning
1. Projection engine	Moves the household through time using starting balances, growth, inflation, wages, Social Security, RMDs, inherited IRA rules, taxes, Medicare/IRMAA, and spending.
2. Funding engine	Figures out how spending, income taxes, and cash needs are funded. It uses automatic income first, then follows the funding order for discretionary account draws.
3. Strategy engine	Lets you test future decisions: Roth conversion targets, Roth conversion sources, IRMAA targets, tax bracket caps, spending changes, survivor planning, cash floors, growth scenarios, and funding order changes.

Three Active Planning Functions

Beyond tracking portfolio movement, the app actively models three decision systems.

FUNDING BUCKETS

The app decides which buckets fund life: wages, Social Security, RMDs, inherited IRA draws, dividends, cash, taxable brokerage, IRA/401k, and Roth.

ROTH CONVERSION INCOME

The app can intentionally create taxable income by converting IRA money to Roth, using rules such as IRMAA tiers or federal tax bracket caps.

PORTFOLIO BUCKET LAB

Optional. You turn it on by account to translate future planned withdrawals into start-of-year Short-Term, Intermediate, and Long/Growth targets, initial seed actions, and later maintenance moves.

Who Benefits Most

User	Why They Might Use It
Retired or near retired	To plan Roth conversions, RMD pressure, Medicare IRMAA exposure, survivor outcomes, cash flow, and account draw order.
Still working	To understand future retirement timing, 401k savings, tax bracket room, and whether Roth conversions before Medicare might help.
Advisor discussion	To bring a concise comparison of possible income targets instead of asking an advisor to react to a giant spreadsheet.

2. First Useful Run

Do not try to optimize everything on day one. The first goal is a simple baseline that is close enough to review.

Step	What to do
1. Open Setup Guide	Enter the household, plan years, starting balances, income, and Medicare/IRMAA lookback if relevant.
2. Use Readiness	Let the app tell you what looks complete, what is missing, and what deserves review.
3. Generate Report	Read the summary, active strategies, and first few action years. Do not worry about every detailed table yet.
4. Save Backup	Export a JSON backup after the baseline makes sense.
5. Open Roth Lab	If Roth conversions matter, save the Current Plan as a User Scenario, then compare a few Roth income targets.
6. Open Bucket Lab	If you want mechanical portfolio withdrawal targets, turn on only the accounts you want to bucket.
7. Print Advisor Report	Use the concise report for discussion with a tax or financial advisor. Bucket Lab appears only when at least one account is enabled.

A good baseline beats a perfect-looking plan that nobody understands. Get the model roughly right, then improve one thing at a time.

What Not To Do First

- Do not start in raw Inputs, Start of Year, or Override Tables unless you already know why you need them.

- Do not compare Roth strategies before the household, balances, income, and Medicare lookback are reasonable.

- Do not turn on Bucket Lab for every account automatically. Use it only for accounts where bucket targets will guide actual portfolio management.

- Do not change five assumptions at once. Change one major thing, rerun, and see what moved.

3. How The Model Thinks About Money

The app works year by year. In each year, money comes in, needs are calculated, and account draws fill the gap.

Layer	What Happens
Automatic income	Wages, self-employment, Social Security, RMDs, inherited IRA required draws, brokerage dividends/interest, and cash interest appear according to setup and strategies.
Required needs	The model funds annual spending, income taxes, and any cash gap needed to rebuild cash toward the target.
Funding order	If automatic income is not enough, the model follows the selected draw order, such as IRA/401k, then taxable brokerage, then Roth.
Roth conversions	A Roth conversion is not spending. It moves money from IRA to Roth and creates taxable income now, usually to reduce future taxable IRA/RMD pressure.
Roth conversion source	The source setting controls which person's IRA supplies the conversion dollars. The Cash Flow tab shows the split by person so the taxable conversion can be audited.
Taxable account buckets	Taxable brokerage income is estimated from entered balances. Regular taxable investments, U.S. Treasuries, CA municipal bonds, and other-state municipal bonds receive different tax treatment.
Bucket Lab targets	Optional portfolio implementation targets. Bucket Lab does not change cash flow, tax, Roth conversion, or funding calculations. It separates the Initial Setup Year from later Review Years so first-year seed actions do not repeat every year.

Important cash-flow convention: annual spending is the household spending budget and is assumed to include normal Medicare premiums. Income taxes are modeled separately. IRMAA is shown separately for planning comparison, but it is not added as a second separate spending withdrawal unless you include it in spending.

Why This Matters

- A Roth conversion can improve future account location but raise current tax or IRMAA.

- An IRA draw used to fund spending is taxable income, so funding choices can change tax results.

- A survivor case can change filing status, tax brackets, Social Security, Medicare count, and account pressure.

- Bucket Lab is a portfolio implementation aid. It helps decide how much of an enabled account might belong in near-term, intermediate, and long/growth holdings at the start of a review year.

4. Pick The Right Path

Different users should pay attention to different parts of the app. This keeps the tool from feeling bigger than the decision in front of you.

RETIRED OR NEAR RETIRED Start with Setup Guide, Medicare lookback, Social Security, RMDs, inherited IRAs if any, and Roth Lab IRMAA scenarios.	**STILL WORKING** Start with wages, 401k defaults, retirement timing, savings assumptions, and tax bracket scenarios. IRMAA may matter later, but it may not be the first question.
WIDOW/WIDOWER PLANNING Use Survivor Plan to understand single-filing tax brackets, Social Security changes, Medicare count, spending changes, and future RMD pressure.	**ADVISOR MEETING** Use the Advisor Report, not the raw tables. Bring a few scenarios and questions rather than every possible detail.

Retired or Near-Retired Workflow

Step	What to do
1. Baseline	Complete Setup Guide and Readiness.
2. Medicare	Enter prior MAGI and review IRMAA assumptions.
3. Roth Lab	Use IRMAA Base through Tier 4 to see how different income targets change taxes, IRMAA, IRA depletion, Roth balance, and net worth.
4. Bucket Lab	If you manage withdrawals by portfolio buckets, enable the IRA, inherited IRA, taxable, or Roth accounts where bucket targets are useful.
5. Advisor Report	Select up to five useful scenarios and print the report.

Working User Workflow

Step	What to do
1. Baseline	Enter wages, 401k defaults, self-employment or 1099 income if any, and retirement timing.
2. Tax focus	Use No Extra Roth, Tax Bracket Fill, or a Federal Bracket Cap if you want to test using tax bracket space.
3. Medicare later	As Medicare approaches, add IRMAA-aware scenarios because Medicare premiums can jump based on income from two years earlier.

5. Setup Guide In Human Order

The Setup Guide is the normal data-entry path. It asks for information in the order most people can answer it.

Setup Screen	Why It Exists
Household	Names, one-person or two-person plan, tax filing, state, plan start year, and plan length.
Survivor Plan	Only needed for two-person plans when testing one spouse dying during the plan.
Assumptions	Global defaults for growth, inflation, dividends, cash interest, spending growth, Social Security COLA, tax bracket inflation, IRMAA MAGI threshold inflation, Medicare cost inflation, cash floor, and draw order.
Opening Year	First-year spending and balances. Taxable brokerage is split into regular taxable investments, U.S. Treasuries, CA municipal bonds, and other-state municipal bonds before IRA/401k, Roth, HSA, and inherited accounts.
Inherited IRAs	Rule details for inherited retirement accounts. Use this only if inherited accounts exist.
Income	Work income and Social Security. Retired users can skip work income if it does not apply.
401k Defaults	Global contribution defaults for people still working.
Medicare & IRMAA	Prior MAGI, Medicare lookback, IRMAA MAGI threshold inflation, Medicare premium and surcharge cost inflation, and default Roth conversion targets.
Review	A checklist that sends you back to the right screen when something needs attention.

Leave truly unused items blank or zero. The app should explain when a blank means 'not applicable' and when a field is actually needed.

Taxable Brokerage And Bond Balances

Opening Year and Annual Check-In ask for taxable-account balances, not annual interest. Put ordinary taxable brokerage holdings in Taxable Stocks/Funds. Use the U.S. Treasury bucket for Treasury or federal-obligation balances, CA Municipal Bond for California municipal bonds, and Other-State Municipal Bond for municipal bonds taxable by California.

These taxable-account buckets are tax-treatment categories. They are separate from Bucket Lab, which is an optional portfolio-planning tool for withdrawal targets.

The model applies the Brokerage Dividend / Interest Rate to those balances to estimate annual income, while the full taxable account still shares the overall Investment Growth Rate.

Bucket	Tax Treatment
Taxable Stocks/Funds	Federally taxable and generally taxable by California.
U.S. Treasury / Federal Obligation	Federally taxable, but exempt from California/state tax.
CA Municipal Bond	Exempt from regular federal and California tax, but included for Social Security provisional income and Medicare MAGI.

Bucket	Tax Treatment
Other-State Municipal Bond	Federally tax-exempt municipal interest that is taxable by California.

Tax Tables And Inflation Assumptions

Tax Tables owns the exact IRS and Medicare tables plus the global inflation assumptions used after the latest table year. Guided Setup shows the same global values in plain-English context; changing them in either place updates the same model setting.

Setting	What It Changes
Tax Bracket Inflation	Annual percent increase for federal tax bracket thresholds after the latest entered tax table year.
IRMAA MAGI Threshold Inflation	Annual percent increase for the MAGI income levels that define each Medicare IRMAA tier. This controls how quickly the income lines move.
Medicare Cost Inflation	Annual percent increase for standard Part B premiums and IRMAA surcharge dollar amounts. This can be higher than threshold inflation so Medicare costs are not understated.

Use an Inflation Assumption Change strategy only when a future year range should use different assumptions than the global Tax Tables settings. Blank strategy fields inherit the global setting, so you can change only Medicare Cost Inflation without changing bracket or IRMAA MAGI threshold inflation.

6. Roth Lab

Roth Lab is the comparison tool for Roth conversion planning. It is for asking: how much income should we intentionally create now by converting IRA money to Roth?

A Roth conversion can reduce future IRA balances, future RMD pressure, and future taxable income. But it can also increase current income tax, state tax, Medicare IRMAA, or cash-flow pressure. Roth Lab puts those tradeoffs side by side.

What Roth Lab Is Not

- It is not a recommendation engine.
- It does not know your risk tolerance, estate goals, tax preparer preferences, or exact future tax law.
- It is a discussion tool so you and an advisor can see the tradeoffs more clearly.

The Main Scenario Families

Scenario	Plain-English Meaning
Current Plan	The plan exactly as currently saved, including existing Roth target rows and strategies.
User Scenario	A saved snapshot of one plan so you can experiment and later restore or compare against it.
No Extra Roth	Turns off intentional Roth conversion targets in the Roth Lab window. Useful as a baseline.
IRMAA Base / Tiers	Medicare-aware targets. These compare converting up to selected Medicare income tiers, less a cushion.
Tax Bracket Fill	Tax-focused target. It fills available federal tax bracket space and ignores Medicare IRMAA tiers.
Federal Bracket Cap	A selected federal bracket ceiling. Useful for working users or users who care more about tax bracket space than IRMAA.

7. How To Use Roth Lab

Step	What to do
1. Save Current Plan	Before experimenting, use Save / Replace User Scenario. This gives you a named plan to restore or compare.
2. Pick a window	Choose the Roth Lab years. Many retirees focus on years before RMDs, before a survivor change, or before inherited IRA deadlines.
3. Start with a preset	Retiree preset compares IRMAA tiers. Working / Tax preset compares tax-bracket choices.
4. Compare scorecards	Look at lifetime Roth conversions, income tax, IRMAA, tax + Medicare impact, final IRA, final Roth, final other assets, final net worth, and weighted effective tax rate.
5. Inspect year-by-year	Use this when a scenario looks surprising. It shows AGI, Roth conversions, IRMAA created, IRMAA paid, taxes, and ending balances.
6. Print Advisor Report	Select up to five scenarios that tell the clearest story and print the concise report.
7. Use a strategy only after deciding	If a scenario becomes the plan, use the strategy button to write the Roth target rows into the plan.

Important Roth Lab Controls

Control	Meaning
IRMAA target	The Medicare income ceiling to aim for, less the cushion.
IRMAA cushion	How far below the IRMAA line to stop, such as $4,000 below the tier threshold.
No extra fill	Do not intentionally convert above the selected target. Funding still follows the normal draw order.
Fill to next tier	If income is already over the selected target, the model may convert toward the next useful tier.
Use Roth above target	If spending or tax funding would require taxable IRA draws above the target, use Roth withdrawals above the target instead.
Federal bracket cap	Optional tax-bracket ceiling. For working users, this may be more relevant than IRMAA.
Roth conversion source	Choose where conversion dollars come from: higher IRA, lower IRA, first person, second person, or a percent split such as 50/50. If one IRA does not have enough available, the model uses the other IRA to finish the target.

Retired users often start with IRMAA Base through Tier 4. Working users often start with No Extra Roth, Tax Bracket Fill, and a conservative federal bracket cap if one has been chosen.

8. Bucket Lab And Portfolio Buckets

Bucket Lab is an optional portfolio implementation tool. It turns the cash-flow plan into an investment-positioning checklist: what should be protected for near-term withdrawals, what should be staged for later withdrawals, and what can remain positioned for long-term growth?

The flow is Long-Term Growth -> Intermediate Bucket -> Short-Term Bucket -> Planned Withdrawals. The Dashboard and main report show actions during one year that prepare the buckets for the following year.

Bucket Lab is off by default. Nothing appears in reports, the dashboard, or Year Detail until you turn on at least one account. This keeps the guide and reports quiet for users who do not manage portfolios with buckets.

What Bucket Lab Does

Bucket Lab Item	Plain-English Meaning
Initial Setup Year	The first year the bucket system should be in place. Seed actions appear only for this year, because this is when you establish the Short-Term and Intermediate buckets for the first time.
Review Year	The year being reviewed for start-of-year targets. Use it for annual check-ins after the initial setup. Dashboard cards show actions in the current year to prepare the next Review Year.
On by account	Turn on only the accounts where bucket targets are useful. For example, you might enable a traditional IRA and an inherited IRA, but leave Roth off.
Short-Term bucket	Money protected for the near-term planned withdrawals shown in the bucket window. In the Initial Setup Year, the app shows a seed action to establish this bucket.
Intermediate bucket	Money staged for future Short-Term refills. In the Initial Setup Year, the app shows a seed action to buy or assign the staged lots for the Intermediate window.
Scheduled moves	Shows money due to move between buckets. Move Year is when the bucket transfer is due; Withdrawal Year is the planned withdrawal year being prepared for.
Long/Growth	Long-term growth and future bucket replenishment.
Annual Bucket Moves	Checklist items that distinguish initial seed actions from later maintenance moves. Planned withdrawals and Roth conversions are handled elsewhere.
Bucket window	The Short-Term / Intermediate year setting for one account. For example, Short-Term 3 years and Intermediate 5 years means three planned withdrawal years in Short-Term, then the next five in Intermediate.

What Bucket Lab Does Not Do

- It does not change the funding engine or account draw order.

- It does not change taxes, Roth conversions, RMDs, IRMAA, or cash-flow results.

- It does not recommend specific securities.

- It does not track whether your real portfolio actually holds those bucket amounts. It calculates targets you can compare with your real holdings.

Typical Bucket Windows

The right bucket window depends on how the account is used. These are starting examples, not investment recommendations.

Example Account	Possible Bucket Window
Traditional IRA	Short-Term 3 / Intermediate 5 might mean three years of expected IRA withdrawals in Short-Term and the following five years in Intermediate.
Post-2020 inherited IRA	Short-Term 2 / Intermediate 0 might be enough when the goal is a shorter required drawdown runway.
Roth IRA	Short-Term 0 / Intermediate 0 keeps Roth entirely in Long/Growth unless the plan has explicit Roth withdrawals.
Taxable securities	Short-Term 2 / Intermediate 3 may help if taxable brokerage is expected to fund spending or cash gaps.
HSA	Short-Term 1 / Intermediate 0 may be enough when only current or near-term medical withdrawals are planned.

How To Use Bucket Lab

Step	What to do
1. Build the baseline first	Bucket targets are only useful after spending, income, balances, inherited IRA lots, and funding order are reasonable.
2. Set Initial Setup Year	Choose the first year the bucket system should be in place. For example, if you want buckets ready at the start of 2027, set Initial Setup Year to 2027.
3. Pick Review Year	Use Review Year for annual check-ins. You can review 2028, 2029, and later years without telling the app to seed the buckets again.
4. Choose report horizon	The Bucket Report selector controls how many review years of scheduled moves appear in the detailed Bucket Lab Report. Three review years is the default; Full Ladder is for longer maturity planning.
5. Turn on accounts	Enable only accounts where bucket targets should appear. The lab remains invisible elsewhere until something is turned on.
6. Set account windows	Enter Short-Term and Intermediate years for each enabled account. Use zero when a bucket should not exist.
7. Compare to real holdings	Use the Dashboard, Year Detail, and main report to compare calculated targets with how the actual account is invested. Use Print Bucket Lab Report when you want detailed withdrawal-year coverage and scheduled moves.
8. Review annually	At each annual check-in, update balances, choose the new Review Year, and use the listed maintenance moves. Seed actions should appear only for the Initial Setup Year.

A simple example: if Initial Setup Year is 2027 and the account uses a 3/5 rule, the 2026 Dashboard card can show actions to seed buckets so 2027 starts ready. Short-Term might cover 2027-2029; Intermediate might cover 2030-2034; Long/Growth is what remains after those targets.

Intermediate Bucket amounts are labeled by Withdrawal Year, which means the future year the dollars are ultimately meant to cover. That does not mean you wait until that year to act. Example: with a 3-year Short-Term window, the 2030 withdrawal should move from Intermediate into Short-Term during the 2028 review, because the

2028 Short-Term Bucket covers 2028-2030. The app does not recommend specific investments, but users who use maturity-based holdings can use the move year as an availability date.
Dashboard, Year Detail, and the main retirement report use prep-year language: a 2026 card can show bucket actions to prepare for 2027, so initial seed actions and later maintenance moves are visible where users review annual details. The Bucket Lab tab shows the selected Review Year as a start-of-year target review. The separate Bucket Lab Report remains the detailed appendix for withdrawal-year coverage, total bucket targets, and scheduled moves between buckets. Use a shorter report horizon for annual maintenance, or Full Ladder when you want to see all future move years.
For inherited IRA drawdown lots, the Short-Term target is capped at the available account balance. If the last planned draw is slightly larger than the current balance because the projection assumes future growth before depletion, Bucket Lab explains that as a drawdown note rather than a target gap.
For inherited IRA lots, Bucket Lab uses stable lot IDs behind the scenes, so a saved rule stays attached to the intended lot rather than to its row position.

9. Advisor Report

The Advisor Report is the clean conversation piece. It is meant to be short enough to discuss and detailed enough to avoid vague guesses.

Report Area	Why It Is There
Key assumptions	Shows the assumptions that could change the answer, such as growth, inflation, survivor plan, Medicare lookback, tax filing, and Roth Lab window.
Scenario comparison	Compares the selected Roth strategies side by side.
Bucket Lab	Appears only when at least one account is enabled. The main report mirrors the Dashboard: actions in the report year prepare buckets for the following year. Use the separate Bucket Lab Report for detailed scheduled moves or full ladder detail.
Year-by-year detail	Shows the first few years or the selected detail range for each scenario.
Advisor questions	Prompts the discussion: which income target is reasonable, whether IRMAA is worth paying, whether survivor planning changes the answer, and whether the strategy should stop at a tier or bracket.

Good Advisor Questions

- Is the selected IRMAA tier worth paying to reduce future IRA and RMD pressure?

- Should conversions stop at an IRMAA tier, a federal bracket, or a custom MAGI amount?

- For the Initial Setup Year, what holdings should seed the Short-Term and Intermediate buckets?

- For later Review Years, which maintenance moves should refill Short-Term or Intermediate?

- Should any inherited IRA lot have a shorter bucket runway than a regular IRA?

- Does the answer change if growth is lower, growth is higher, or one spouse dies earlier?

- Should taxes be paid from cash, taxable brokerage, IRA, or Roth in specific years?

- Are estate goals more important than lowest lifetime tax in this plan?

The Advisor Report is not trying to win the argument. It is trying to make the right argument visible.

10. Annual Check-In And Strategy Builder

The first setup is only the starting map. Annual Check-In and Strategy Builder keep the map useful.

ANNUAL CHECK-IN	STRATEGY BUILDER
Use once a year to enter real balances, taxable-account bond buckets, real income, and other actual details. This keeps the model anchored to reality.	Use for future decisions: spending changes, Roth targets, cash floors, growth scenarios, tax timing, and funding order changes.

Annual Check-In

Step	What to do
Pick year	Choose the year being updated.
Enter actuals	Update spending, income, HSA, inherited IRA values, and balances. For taxable accounts, enter the balance split between taxable investments, Treasuries, CA munis, and other-state munis.
Review Bucket Lab	If bucket targets are enabled, confirm the Initial Setup Year, compare the Review Year start-of-year targets with actual holdings, and use scheduled maintenance moves to decide what needs moving.
Rerun report	Generate a fresh report so the action plan reflects reality.

Strategy Builder

Strategy	Use It For
Spending change	A future lifestyle change, one-time cost, or spending reduction.
Tax funding / deferred tax	A year-specific tax funding choice, such as paying less estimated tax this year and catching up later.
Roth conversion / IRMAA target	A rule for intentional Roth conversion income.
Roth conversion source	A year-range rule for which IRA supplies conversion dollars: higher IRA, lower IRA, either named person first, or a percent split.
Income target	A custom taxable income ceiling.
Portfolio return scenario	A selected year range with a different assumed growth rate.
Inflation assumption change	A selected year range with different tax bracket, IRMAA MAGI threshold, or Medicare cost inflation assumptions. Blank fields inherit Tax Tables.
Cash floor	A future change to the cash reserve target.
Funding order	A future change to which accounts are tapped first.

Add notes to strategies. A note that seems obvious today may save Future You from wondering why a rule exists.

11. Setup Reference

Use this section when a field is confusing. You do not need to memorize it before using the app.

Area	Key Plain-English Notes
Household	Names are used in labels. One-person plans hide spouse and survivor setup. Two-person plans usually default to Married Filing Jointly.
Birth years	Used for age, Social Security, Medicare, RMDs, and senior deduction timing.
Plan start and length	The first and last years shown in reports. Pick enough years to cover retirement, Medicare, RMDs, inherited IRA deadlines, and survivor planning.
Cash	Non-IRA cash or near-cash only: bank accounts, money markets, CDs, short-term Treasuries, or similar reserves.
Securities / brokerage	Taxable investment money outside IRA and Roth accounts. Enter it by tax bucket when possible: taxable stocks/funds, U.S. Treasuries, CA municipal bonds, and other-state municipal bonds.
IRA / 401k	Traditional retirement money. Withdrawals and conversions are usually taxable.
Roth conversion source	For two-person plans, this controls whose traditional IRA is converted first or how conversions are split. It changes the source account, not the conversion target amount.
Tax Tables inflation settings	Global assumptions for how tax brackets, IRMAA MAGI tier thresholds, and Medicare premium/surcharge dollars grow after the latest exact table year. Use strategies only for future-year exceptions.
Roth	Roth IRA or Roth 401k money. Qualified withdrawals are usually tax-free.
HSA	Health Savings Account. Leave blank or zero if none exists.
Social Security	Enter current monthly benefit if already receiving. Otherwise enter start age and estimated monthly benefit at that age.
W-2 withholding	Optional. Most users can leave blank so the model calculates income tax separately.

12. Inherited IRA Reference

Use inherited IRA setup only for inherited retirement accounts. Regular IRA, 401k, Roth, and HSA balances belong in Opening Year.

Field	Meaning
Beneficiary	Whose inherited IRA rules and age apply.
Starting balance	The balance at the beginning of the first modeled year for that lot. If setting up in 2026, use the 2026/current balance, not the original inheritance amount.
Distributions begin year	The first year this inherited IRA lot is active for projection draws. It is a modeling choice, not automatically the year after death.
Death year	For post-2020 lots, this sets the 10-year deadline. For pre-2020 lots, it helps calculate life-expectancy RMDs.
Deceased owner birth year	Used to determine whether annual RMDs apply before a final deadline.
Draw strategy	How optional draws are spread before the deadline.
Pre-2020 lots	Add separate lots when accounts came from different owners, different death years, or different beneficiaries. Combine only when they use the same RMD schedule.

Inherited IRA rules can be unforgiving. When in doubt, use the app to model cash flow, but confirm required distribution rules with a tax professional or custodian.

13. Advanced Mode, Backups, And Glossary

Advanced Mode shows the raw machine room: Inputs, Start of Year, Override Tables, Year Detail, Cash Flow, Tax Summary, Tax Tables, and Export/Import. Most users can leave it off.

Use Export/Import for JSON backups. Make a backup after setup, after annual check-ins, before major strategy testing, and after changes you would not want to recreate.

Term	Plain-English Meaning
AGI / MAGI	Income measures used for tax and Medicare planning. Medicare IRMAA uses a MAGI-style lookback.
IRMAA	Extra Medicare premium for higher income.
IRMAA MAGI threshold inflation	How fast the MAGI income levels for IRMAA tiers increase each year after the latest exact table year.
Medicare cost inflation	How fast standard Part B premiums and IRMAA surcharge dollar amounts increase after the latest exact table year.
RMD	Required minimum distribution from some retirement accounts.
Roth conversion	Moving IRA money to Roth and paying tax now so future qualified Roth withdrawals may be tax-free.
Roth conversion source	The IRA account used for conversion dollars. This can be higher IRA, lower IRA, a named person first, or a percent split.

Term	Plain-English Meaning
Tax-free bond buckets	Taxable-account balance entries for U.S. Treasuries and municipal bonds so federal and California tax treatment can differ.
Bucket Lab	Optional account-by-account portfolio bucket planner for initial seed targets, start-of-year review targets, and scheduled bucket moves. It is off by default and appears in reports only after at least one account is enabled.
Short-Term bucket	The enabled account target for planned withdrawals inside the near-term funding window.
Intermediate bucket	The enabled account target for planned withdrawals after the short window but inside the intermediate window.
Long/Growth	The remaining enabled account balance after Short and Intermediate targets.
Funding order	The order used when the model needs extra money from accounts.
Cash floor	The cash reserve target the model tries to protect.
Cushion / headroom	A safety amount below a target, such as staying $4,000 below an IRMAA tier.
Strategy / override	A rule for selected years that changes the default plan.
Weighted effective tax rate	A blended tax-rate measure weighted by taxable income, so very small or zero-income years do not distort the comparison.

Best habit: build a simple baseline, export a backup, test one strategy, compare, then either keep it or remove it. Clear experiments beat giant mystery scenarios.